

NERAI Maritime Weekly

The week's most consequential events, selected by strategic consequence and grounded in a 91-article 7-day corpus plus live NERAI data.

THE WEEK IN BRIEF - The Gulf crisis deepened materially this week as Hormuz physical oil flow remained at -96.4% versus baseline while NERAI's 4-week disruption probability fell 6.8 points to 44% — a sustained divergence between the forward model and the water that warrants close monitoring. Simultaneously, Houthi consolidation of Bab el-Mandeb accelerated, closing the Cape-of-Good-Hope reroute valve from the Red Sea side, and the Saudi East-West pipeline sustained a second alleged strike, eliminating the last credible overland Hormuz bypass. Diplomatic activity in Muscat produced a technical framework on Hormuz transit lanes but no signed agreement, leaving the strategic picture unresolved heading into next week.

01 FOLLOW-UP - Hormuz Blockade: 4-Week Risk Falls 6.8 pts Even as Oil Flow Stays at -96.4% — Divergence Persists

FOLLOW-UP - underlying action predates this window | event date: 2026-09-13

WHY IT RANKS - The sustained, growing gap between the forward model (risk falling) and physical reality (flow still near-zero) is the single most decision-relevant signal for energy traders, insurers and compliance teams this week.

Hormuz physical oil flow stood at 0.7 mb/d, down -96.4% versus baseline as of 14 September 2026, a level essentially unchanged from last week's severe reading. Yet NERAI's 4-week disruption probability fell 6.8 points to 44% and the 8-week probability fell 4.9 points to 72%, a directional divergence from the physical data. Multiple outlets reported that shipping traffic through Hormuz has fallen to single digits, with tankers transiting in AIS-dark mode. U.S. CENTCOM stated it had redirected 99 commercial ships as Iran's maritime posture continued; Iran warned of 'more painful' retaliation after U.S. strikes on Iranian oil vessels.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - A forward-model decline while physical flows remain near-zero implies the model is pricing in a negotiated resolution or ceasefire probability that the water has not yet confirmed — a classic divergence that has historically preceded either a sharp model correction upward or a genuine diplomatic breakthrough. CENTCOM's redirection of 99 commercial ships is operationally significant: it signals that U.S. naval escort capacity is being stretched and that the effective throughput of Gulf trade depends on active military management, not free passage. Tankers transiting in AIS-dark mode degrades tracking-firm volume estimates sharply, meaning the 0.7 mb/d figure could overstate or understate actual flow — compliance teams cannot rely on it as a clean loading confirmation. Supertanker spot rates reported at \$800,000 per day create a freight-cost shock that will propagate into refined-product prices across South and Southeast Asia within weeks; Philippine fuel prices were already reported above P100 and forecast to climb further. War-risk and P&I; cover reviews are not automatic but the sustained dark-transit pattern and active attack environment make upward pressure on war-risk pricing probable. The Bandar Abbas port call drop of 70.5 points to -39.7% versus its 90-day average (NERAI, observed 2026-09-13) corroborates that Iranian export logistics are severely impaired beyond tanker flow alone.

NERAI SIGNAL - Strait of Hormuz chokepoint oil flow: 0.7 mb/d, -96.4% vs baseline (SEVERE); 4-week disruption probability fell from 51% to 44% (-6.8 pts); Bandar Abbas port calls -39.7% vs 90-day average (SEVERE DROP) [all observed 2026-09-13/14, NERAI].

Sources: english.aawsat.com: <https://english.aawsat.com/world/5317023-hormuz-shipping-traffic-falls-single-digits> | khaama.com: <https://www.khaama.com/centcom-says-us-redirected-99-commercial-ships-as-iran-maritime-blockade-continues/> | finance.yahoo.com: <https://finance.yahoo.com/energy/articles/supertanker-rates-hit-800-000-160000148.html>

02 Oman-Mediated Hormuz Talks: Technical Framework Agreed, No Signed Deal Yet

NEW EVENT | event date: 2026-09-13

WHY IT RANKS - A diplomatic framework on Hormuz transit lanes — even without a signed agreement — is the most consequential potential de-escalation signal of the week and directly conditions the forward-model divergence identified above.

On 13 September 2026, reports emerged that Iran and Oman agreed on new entry and exit routes for the Strait of Hormuz at talks in Muscat. However, an Iranian official stated that no signed Hormuz deal was expected yet from the Monday meeting, confirming the framework remains preliminary. The UN Secretary-General had already stated he was 'deeply concerned' over Strait of Hormuz escalation. No signed ceasefire or operational reopening was announced as of the corpus date.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - An Omani-mediated technical framework on transit lanes is diplomatically significant because it implies both parties are engaging on the operational architecture of a future reopening — but the Iranian official's explicit downgrading of expectations ('no signed deal yet') signals this is a confidence-building step, not a resolution. The gap between a technical agreement and a commercially usable strait is large: insurers, flag states and port authorities will require a sustained, verifiable period of safe passage before war-risk ratings are revised downward. Oman's role as interlocutor is consistent with its historical position as the Gulf's back-channel broker, and its leverage is heightened by the current crisis. For the forward model, a successful framework — even unsigned — may be partially responsible for the 6.8-point drop in the 4-week disruption probability, but the physical flow reading of -96.4% means the market should treat any probability decline with caution until transit volumes confirm recovery. If talks collapse, the model's current downward trajectory would be expected to reverse sharply. Energy-importing nations in South and Southeast Asia have the most immediate stake in a resolution.

NERAI SIGNAL - Strait of Hormuz 4-week disruption probability: 44% (-6.8 pts since 2026-09-07); 8-week: 72% (-4.9 pts) [observed 2026-09-13, NERAI]. The probability decline is consistent with a market partially pricing in diplomatic progress, while physical flow at -96.4% has not yet confirmed it.

Sources: iranherald.com: <http://www.iranherald.com/news/279304065/iran-oman-agree-on-new-entry-exit-routes-for-strait-of-hormuz-report> | arynews.tv: <https://arynews.tv/news/liveblog/iran-war-2026-live-updates-trump-us-israel?update=13-Sep-2026-09-55-00> | middleeastmonitor.com: <https://www.middleeastmonitor.com/20260909-un-chief-deeply-concerned-over-strait-of-hormuz-escalation/>

03 FOLLOW-UP - Saudi East-West Pipeline Struck Again — Last Hormuz Bypass Remains Disabled

FOLLOW-UP - underlying action predates this window | event date: 2026-09-12

WHY IT RANKS - A second alleged Houthi strike on the Saudi East-West pipeline confirms the destruction of the last viable overland Hormuz bypass is not a one-time event but an ongoing, contested interdiction, with direct consequences for global oil supply redundancy.

On 12 September 2026, a huge fire broke out along the Saudi East-West pipeline following alleged Houthi strikes, according to multiple reports. The pipeline is Saudi Arabia's primary overland route connecting Eastern Province oil fields to the Red Sea port of Yanbu, bypassing the Strait of Hormuz. Saudi Arabia had already shut the pipeline following earlier strikes (covered in W38); this week's reported fire and continued Houthi strikes on the Saudi border confirm the bypass remains disabled and under active threat. Reports on 13 September confirmed Houthis continued striking at the Saudi Arabian border while tightening their grip on the oil route.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - With the East-West pipeline disabled and Hormuz physical flow at -96.4%, Saudi Arabia has no functioning export route that bypasses the active conflict zone in the Gulf — a situation with no modern precedent in duration. The UAE pipeline to Fujairah remains the only other Gulf-to-Red-Sea overland bypass in the region, and its capacity and exposure should now be the subject of urgent underwriter and government scrutiny. The Bab el-Mandeb situation (see Event 4) means that even if Yanbu or Fujairah loadings were restored, onward transit to Europe and Asia via the Red Sea faces its own disruption. The convergence of both bypass routes under threat simultaneously is the 'illusion of redundancy' dynamic identified in the corpus: market assumptions about alternative routing have been structurally undermined. Canadian oil exports were reported to be benefiting from elevated prices, illustrating how supply-chain shocks redistribute rents globally. Shadow-fleet pressure rising 4.4 points to 48.3 (Moderate, NERAI) suggests non-transparent tonnage is being mobilised to capture the freight premium, raising compliance and sanctions-evasion risks for buyers.

NERAI SIGNAL - Shadow-fleet pressure index rose +4.4 to 48.3 (Moderate) [observed 2026-09-13, NERAI], consistent with elevated demand for non-transparent tonnage as conventional Gulf routing collapses.

Sources: sott.net: <https://www.sott.net/article/508351-Huge-fire-breaks-out-along-Saudi-Hormuz-bypass-East-West-Oil-Pipeline-after-alleged-Houthi-Strikes> | tradearabia.com: <https://tradedarabia.com:443/News/486090/Saudi-pipeline-shutdown-raises-fresh-threat-of-oil-price-surge>

04 FOLLOW-UP - Houthis Consolidate Bab el-Mandeb Control: Mocha Port, Perim Island Held; IRGC Officers Deployed

FOLLOW-UP - underlying action predates this window | event date: 2026-09-10

WHY IT RANKS - Houthi physical control of both the port of Mocha and Perim Island, combined with reported IRGC officer deployments, transforms Bab el-Mandeb from a threatened corridor into a partially administered one, directly constraining Cape rerouting from the Red Sea side.

CNN reported on 10 September 2026 that Houthi forces captured the Red Sea port of Mocha, described as tightening their grip on a key global chokepoint. Separately, Gulf News reported on 11 September that Iran deployed IRGC officers to Yemen to support Houthi operations targeting Bab el-Mandeb and global shipping. Perim Island, which dominates the narrowest point of Bab el-Mandeb, was reported seized in W38 and remains under Houthi control. Bab el-Mandeb physical oil flow stood at 5.1 mb/d, down -41.7% versus baseline as of 14 September 2026.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - Mocha's capture gives Houthis a logistics node on the Red Sea coast capable of supporting small-boat interdiction operations across the strait; combined with Perim Island, they now control both the coastline and the mid-channel geography of Bab el-Mandeb's narrowest passage. The reported IRGC deployment — attributed to Gulf News and framed as an allegation — would, if accurate, represent a qualitative escalation in Iranian operational involvement, moving from arms supply and intelligence to direct officer-level command integration. For shipping, the practical consequence is that Cape of Good Hope rerouting, already the primary workaround for Red Sea disruption, now faces the risk of vessels completing a full southern African circumnavigation only to encounter a controlled strait at journey's end. Cape of Good Hope oil flow has itself deteriorated 22.2 points to -12.7% versus baseline this week (NERAI), suggesting the reroute is already under pressure from factors beyond Bab el-Mandeb alone. Eastern Mediterranean 8-week disruption probability at 82% (+0.5 pts, NERAI) reflects the downstream consequence: if both Bab el-Mandeb and Suez are stressed, Eastern Mediterranean supply security deteriorates materially. P&I; clubs and war-risk underwriters writing Red Sea and Gulf of Aden coverage should treat Mocha and Perim control as a structural, not episodic, risk factor.

NERAI SIGNAL - Bab el-Mandeb chokepoint oil flow: 5.1 mb/d, -41.7% vs baseline (SEVERE); Cape of Good Hope oil flow deteriorated 22.2 pts to -12.7% vs baseline; Eastern Mediterranean 8-week disruption probability: 82% (+0.5 pts since 2026-09-07) [all observed 2026-09-13/14, NERAI].

Sources: edition.cnn.com: <https://edition.cnn.com/2026/09/10/middleeast/houthis-capture-mocha-red-sea-strait-intl> | gulfnews.com: <https://gulfnews.com/world/mena/iran-deploys-hundreds-of-irgc-officers-to-yemen-to-target-bab-al-mandab-strait-1.500670468> | ibtimes.co.uk: <https://www.ibtimes.co.uk/saudi-red-sea-oil-route-houthi-bab-el-mandeb-1819153>

05 Iranian Commercial Vessel Struck Near Qeshm; Iran Attributes Attack to U.S., 1 Killed, 3 Injured

FOLLOW-UP - underlying action predates this window | event date: 2026-09-13

WHY IT RANKS - A strike on an Iranian commercial vessel inside the Hormuz approaches — with Iranian authorities publicly attributing it to the U.S. — raises the risk of direct retaliatory escalation against commercial shipping and complicates the Muscat diplomatic track.

On 13 September 2026, Iranian media reported that one person was killed and three injured after an Iranian commercial vessel was struck near Qeshm Island in the Strait of Hormuz. Iranian authorities attributed the attack to the United States, describing it as a 'US attack on a commercial vessel in the Gulf'; this attribution is Iran's claim and has not been independently verified in the corpus. Separately, Iran was reported to have struck a U.S. spy drone in the Strait of Hormuz on 12 September 2026, further escalating the military confrontation in the waterway.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - Iranian attribution of a commercial vessel strike to the United States — regardless of its accuracy — is strategically significant because it provides political cover and domestic justification for retaliatory action against non-Iranian commercial shipping, exactly the category of vessel that CENTCOM has been escorting. The pattern of tit-for-tat strikes on tankers and commercial vessels (Iran and U.S. hit tankers in the biggest wave of attacks since the war began, per corpus) is creating a generalised threat environment in which flag-state and cargo-owner discrimination is degrading: all vessels transiting the approaches become potential targets. The drone strike on 12 September, if confirmed, adds a new dimension — IRGC air-defence engagement of U.S. ISR assets reduces the surveillance coverage that makes escort operations viable. For the 44 Indian seafarers reported caught in Gulf attacks (all reported safe), this week illustrates the crew-welfare and flag-state liability dimension that is increasingly salient for Asian shipowners. Insurance markets should note that the 'commercial vessel' category is no longer protected by any implicit belligerent restraint, materially expanding the insured-loss exposure. The Muscat diplomatic track on Hormuz transit lanes (Event 2) becomes simultaneously more urgent and more fragile following this incident.

NERAI SIGNAL - Strait of Hormuz transit: -92.7% vs baseline (SEVERE chokepoint); corridor escalation score: 37.7; news score: 47.0 [observed 2026-09-13, NERAI]. The escalation and news scores are moving in the same direction as the physical attack data, confirming signal alignment rather than divergence.

Sources: thefrontierpost.com: <https://thefrontierpost.com/iran-says-us-attack-on-commercial-vessel-in-gulf-kills-1-injures-3/> | rte.ie: <https://www.rte.ie/news/2026/0913/1591336-iran-war/> | naturalnews.com: <https://www.naturalnews.com/2026-09-12-iran-strikes-us-spy-drone-strait-of-hormuz.html>

Grounded generation: events are selected only from the week's retrieved article corpus and NERAI feeds; every event carries its sources; each event states the date the issuing authority acted, which is distinct from the date any article about it was published; quantitative figures carry their observation period; maximum five events, fewer when the week is thin. NERAI-UNRESTRICTED.